The results were also a stinging defeat for the Tejaswi Yadav-led Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD), which not only lost two of its strongholds—Ramgarh and Belaganj—but also faced an erosion of its vote base. The loss in Ramgarh was particularly bitter as its candidate Ajit Singh was relegated to third position. The RJD's desperation to retain Belaganj—a seat it controlled for over three decades—was evident, as the party roped in Osama Saheb, son of the late *bahubali* Shahabuddin, to consolidate Muslim votes in favour of its Yadav candidate Vishwanath Kumar Singh. Even party patriarch Lalu Prasad Yadav campaigned in the constituency to rally the traditional Muslim-Yadav voter base. But all its efforts came to nought, raising questions about the party's preparedness for the upcoming state election.

The NDA's success can be attributed to strategic candidate selection and effective consolidation of core support. By fielding candidates who appealed to both traditional backers and disgruntled RJD voters, the NDA managed to corner support from various quarters. For instance, the JD(U)'s decision to nominate Manorama Devi, a Yadav, in Belaganj split the community's vote. Similarly, HAM(S) was able to consolidate the support of the Musahar community by fielding Deepa in Imamganj.

The disruptive influence of Prashant Kishor's newly launched Jan Suraaj Party (JSP) cannot be overemphasised either. It made an unexpected impact by slicing into the RJD's vote share in Imamganj and Belaganj, though its candidates lost their deposits elsewhere. With these results, the NDA now holds 130 seats in the 243-member assembly. This serves as a wake-up call for the RJD-led Opposition, setting the stage for a fierce contest in 2025. ■

–Amitabh Srivastava



POLE POSITION Rajasthan CM Bhajan Lal Sharma

RAJASTHAN

TIMELY BOOST FOR CM SHARMA

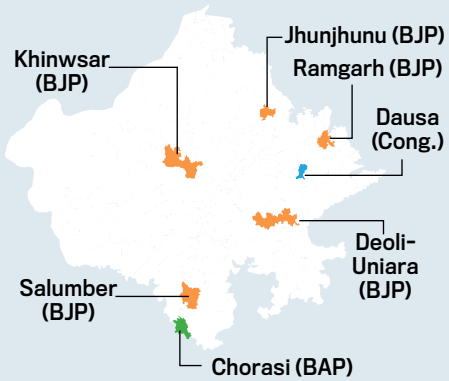
The Rajasthan CM secures a resounding win, silencing critics and cementing his position

Byelections in: **7 seats** | Won by: **BJP 5**; **Cong. 1**; **BAP 1**

Just ahead of his first anniversary in power, Chief Minister Bhajan Lal Sharma has led the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) to a remarkable victory in the Rajasthan bypolls. The party secured five out of seven seats, a dramatic improvement from holding just one of these constituencies previously.

The scale of the bypolls, with seven constituencies spanning diverse caste and religious demographics, would be a tough litmus test for Sharma's leadership. He successfully rose to the challenge, personally leading 14 rallies and conducting 44 meetings with social groups. Not only does the outcome accord stability to his regime, it also showcases Sharma's ability to subdue rivals within the cabinet and the party. BJP general secretary Radha Mohan Agarwal has already declared that the 2028 state election will be fought under Sharma, ending speculation about any leadership change for now.

In fact, in Dausa, BJP's dissident tribal leader Kirodi Lal Meena's brother Jagmohan lost to the Congress. This curtails Meena's ability to challenge Sharma. Even the BJP dealt a blow to several political dynasties—for instance, the loss of Rashtriya Loktantrik Party (RLP) chief Hanuman Beniwal's wife Kanika in Khinwsar. Similarly, the Congress's Amit Ola, son of MP Brijendra Singh Ola, and



Aryan Khan, son of previous incumbents Safia and Jubair Khan, suffered defeats in Jhunjhunu and Ramgarh, respectively. But the Bharat Adivasi Party (BAP) managed to retain its stronghold of Chorasi.

As the Congress faced a sharp decline, relegated to third place in four constituencies and even losing deposits in three, internal rifts are being blamed. During nominations, the party had mostly gone with the recommendations of its MPs, so these defeats also reflected badly upon them.

With the BJP's tally climbing to 119 in the 200-seat assembly, Sharma may have got a big boost but maintaining momentum will require administrative reform, particularly addressing inefficiencies within the bureaucracy and law enforcement. ■

–Rohit Parihar